

Stop Mice Coming Back: The Entry Point Inspection Method

A homeowner's step-by-step guide to finding every gap, sealing it right, and ending the recurring mouse problem for good.

Page 1: Why Mice Keep Coming Back After You've Tried Everything

You set traps. Maybe you called an exterminator. You saw a mouse the next week anyway.

This is the part nobody tells you: traps kill mice. They don't stop new ones from arriving.

A single female mouse can produce 10 litters per year, with an average of 5-6 pups per litter. That's 50-60 new mice per year from one breeding pair. Even if you kill every mouse in your house tonight, you're still open for business tomorrow if the holes they use aren't sealed.

Most exterminator visits follow the same pattern. Spray treatment inside. Maybe some bait stations. The technician leaves. The mice that survived scatter. New mice follow the scent trails left behind and find the same entry points — still wide open.

The homeowners who solve this permanently do one thing differently: they find where the mice are getting in, and they seal it.

This guide walks you through exactly how to do that. Room by room. Gap by gap. No biology lecture, no expensive equipment. Just a flashlight, some basic materials, and a clear method that actually works.

Page 2: The 1/4-Inch Rule

Here's the fact that makes mouse prevention counterintuitive: you are not looking for big holes.

A mouse can squeeze through an opening roughly 1/4 inch in diameter. That's about the size of a dime. A mouse does not need a gap under your door — it needs a gap the width of a dime somewhere in your foundation, your garage wall, or your basement.

This is why most homeowners fail the first time. They look for obvious openings. They seal the gap under the garage door they can see. They patch the crack in the basement wall they noticed. They miss the six other openings that are each smaller than a dime.

Understanding the 1/4-inch rule changes your inspection. You are not looking for places a rat could fit through. You are looking for places a mouse could fit through — which is almost anywhere in your home's exterior envelope if the gap was cut wrong during construction, if the foundation shifted, or if a vent cover pulled loose.

What 1/4 inch looks like in practice: - The opening around a utility line where it penetrates your foundation - The gap between a dryer vent and its cover - The space behind a bathroom exhaust fan where the duct connects - The gap where your garage door frame meets the concrete floor at the corners

All of these can be 1/4 inch or larger and easy to miss because they are not in your line of sight at eye level.

Page 3: The Entry Point Room-by-Room Inspection

Work from the outside of your home inward. Walk the perimeter first, then inspect interior areas where mice commonly nest or travel.

Foundation: Inspect where the foundation meets the ground. Look for: - Gaps where water pipes, gas lines, or electrical conduits penetrate the foundation wall - Cracks in the foundation itself, especially at corners and where the foundation meets framing - Gaps at the top of the foundation where it meets the sill plate - Vents that are damaged, missing screens, or have gaps at the edges

Garage: The garage is the most common entry point in most homes. Mice love it because it is warm, often cluttered, and connects directly to the rest of the house. - The gap where the garage door frame meets the concrete floor (especially at the corners) - Spaces where the walls meet the garage floor — this is one of the most commonly missed entry points - Gaps around the overhead garage door torsion spring cover - Any opening where the garage connects to the home's living space (gaps around the door between garage and house) - Openings around the automatic garage door opener's wire conduit

Kitchen and basement: These are ground zero for mouse activity once they are inside. - Gaps behind kitchen appliances (refrigerator, stove, dishwasher) where pipes and wires enter the wall - Pipe penetrations through basement walls and floors - Floor drains that are not sealed or have broken covers - Gaps around the water heater and

furnace intake/exhaust pipes - Any opening where your home's plumbing vent pipes exit through the roof (the gaps at the roof line, not just the vent cover)

HVAC and vents: - Dryer vent gaps where the flex duct connects to the vent hood - Bathroom exhaust fan openings (these often have large gaps between the fan housing and the ceiling) - HVAC return air openings in the basement or crawl space - Any wall vent with a damaged or missing cover

Doors and windows: - Worn or missing door sweeps on exterior doors - Gaps in the weather stripping at the bottom of exterior doors - Window frame gaps, especially on ground-floor and basement windows

Write down every gap you find. Do not decide yet whether it is big enough. Mark it with painter's tape and come back to measure.

Page 4: The Flashlight Tracking Method

The goal of the flashlight tracking method is to distinguish between an old gap that has been inactive and an active gap that mice are currently using. This matters because you want to seal the active ones first.

What to look for: - **Droppings:** Fresh mouse droppings are dark, moist, and look like dark rice grains. Old droppings are gray, dried out, and crumble when touched. If you find fresh droppings near a gap, that gap is active. - **Urine pillars:** In areas with heavy mouse traffic, the urine accumulates and dries into small, hardened mounds. These take time to form and indicate a well-established mouse highway. - **Rub marks:** Mice follow walls consistently. Where they brush against surfaces repeatedly, you will see dark smudges along baseboards and wall edges. - **Nesting material:** Shredded paper, cardboard, insulation, or fabric pulled into balls. Look in the back corners of cabinets, inside cabinet hinge spaces, behind water heaters, and in the back corners of closets.

The dusk timing: Mice are most active starting at dusk. If you want to actually see mice moving — confirming which entry points are active — do your inspection with a flashlight around sunset. Stand quietly outside near your foundation and listen. You will often hear them moving in the garage or inside the walls.

The flour test: If you suspect a gap is active but are not sure, sprinkle a thin layer of flour or baby powder in front of it overnight. Check in the morning for footprints. Any track through the powder means that gap is in active use.

Page 5: Sealing Gaps — The Right Material for Each Gap Type

Most homeowners use one product for everything and end up with failures. Here is what actually works for each gap type.

Small gaps under 1/2 inch: Steel wool stuffed into the gap, then covered with a layer of caulk. This is the gold standard for gaps around pipe penetrations, small foundation cracks, and gaps where wiring enters the home. Steel wool alone will close the gap. Caulk over it holds it in place and seals against air and moisture. Mice cannot chew through steel wool the way they chew through spray foam.

Gaps around pipes (1/2 inch to 2 inches): Expanding foam sealant formulated for pest control (such as gap foam or pest-block expanding foam). Regular expanding foam from the hardware store works, but mice can chew through it over time. The pest-block formulas add a bitter additive mice find unappealing. After the foam cures, cover it with hardware cloth for permanent protection.

Larger gaps (over 1/2 inch) and vent openings: Hardware cloth — steel mesh with openings of 1/4 inch or smaller. Attach it with screws or staples over the opening, then seal the edges with caulk. For larger gaps, you may need to create a frame with wood strips first, then attach the hardware cloth.

Garage door gaps: Garage door seals (rubber or vinyl) that attach to the bottom of the door. These are inexpensive (\$10-\$20 per door) and replace the worn seals that are common on older garage doors. At the corners of the garage door frame, stuff steel wool into any gap, then seal with caulk.

Door sweeps: Attach to the bottom of exterior doors. Measure your door width first — most are 36 inches. Door sweeps cost \$8-\$20 and are the most cost-effective prevention measure for exterior doors.

What NOT to use: - Spray foam alone: mice chew through it - Dryer sheets: they do not repel mice; this is a myth - Cotton balls: mice use them as nesting material - Ultrasonic devices: ineffective, not supported by research

Page 6: Trap Placement That Actually Catches Mice

Sealing is step one. Trapping handles the mice already inside. Done right, this is a short-term effort. Done wrong, you will be buying traps for years.

Snap traps vs. glue traps vs. live traps:

Snap traps are the most effective for killing mice quickly. They are reusable, inexpensive (about \$1 each in bulk), and work reliably when baited and placed correctly.

Glue traps catch mice but do not kill them quickly. The mouse is stuck and suffers. This is not a humane option — it is a prolonged death. If you use glue traps, check them at least every 4 hours or use a different method.

Live traps catch mice alive and let you release them. They work but require more handling and must be checked frequently to avoid the captured mouse dying of stress or dehydration. They are also larger and more expensive.

Use snap traps. They are the most reliable option.

Where to place traps: Mice run along walls. They do not cross open floor space in the middle of a room. This is why most trap failures happen — people put traps in the center of a room or under kitchen tables.

Place traps: - Directly against the wall, with the trigger plate facing the wall (so the mouse has to reach across the plate to get the bait) - In corners — mice turn corners along walls, and they slow down at turns - Behind appliances and furniture, along the wall line - In cabinets, especially under the kitchen sink and in the back corners of lower cabinets - Near gaps you have found and plan to seal — catch the ones using that entry point tonight

The bait that actually works: Peanut butter is the standard recommendation but it dries out and loses effectiveness after a day or two. A better approach: peanut butter + a small piece of wax paper.

Put a dab of peanut butter on a piece of wax paper and place it over the trigger plate. The wax paper holds the peanut butter in place and the mouse has to work at it, which increases the chance of triggering the trap. You can also use bacon bits, hazelnut spread, or oats crimped into the trigger mechanism.

Do not use cheese. Mice are not particularly attracted to cheese and it falls off the trap easily.

How many traps: Start with 6-8 traps in the primary activity zone (kitchen and basement, or wherever you have seen the most signs). Place them 6-10 feet apart along walls. You can add more if you catch multiple mice in the first 48 hours.

Check traps daily. A trap that has caught a mouse needs to be reset. An untouched trap after 3 days should be moved to a new location.

Page 7: The Complete 14-Day Protocol

This is the sequence that works when you follow it completely.

Day 1-2: Inspection and sealing Walk the entire exterior of your home with a flashlight and a roll of painter's tape. Mark every gap you find with tape and a note. Go room by room inside as well. At the end of Day 1, you should have a complete list of every gap, crack, and opening.

Purchase your materials based on the gaps you found: - Steel wool rolls (\$5) - Caulk and caulk gun (\$8) - Expanding foam sealant, pest-block formula (\$7) - Hardware cloth, 1/4-inch mesh (\$15) - Door sweeps (\$10-\$20 each) - Snap traps (\$1 each, buy at least 12)

Seal every gap on Day 2. Start with the exterior gaps — foundation penetrations, garage gaps, door sweeps. Move inside to gaps behind appliances and pipe penetrations.

Day 3-5: Trap placement Set snap traps along walls in the kitchen, basement, garage, and any other active areas. Place them as described in Page 6. Do not use poison bait in the first phase — you want snap traps so you can confirm what you are catching and where.

Check traps each morning. Reset or relocate as needed.

Day 6-10: Monitoring and adjustment By Day 6, if mice are still being caught, you have at least one active entry point you did not find. Go back outside with the flour test. Sprinkle flour in front of suspected gaps and check for footprints in the morning. Look for new droppings near sealed gaps.

If you are catching mice but the number is not declining, there is still an active entry. Keep sealing.

Day 11-14: Confirm and wrap up If you have not caught a mouse in 5 consecutive days, the active population inside is likely eliminated. Do a final inspection: check all your seals (some may have been chewed or have settled), confirm no new droppings have appeared, and remove the traps or convert them to permanent monitoring stations with fresh bait monthly.

Page 8: Remove the Reason They Came

Sealing gaps keeps mice out. Removing what attracts them makes your home less appealing even if a gap is temporarily missed.

Food sources: - Store pet food in glass, metal, or thick plastic containers with tight lids. The bags pet food comes in are easy to chew through. - Do not leave pet food in bowls overnight. Feed your pet, then put the bowl away. - Keep pantry items in glass or metal containers. Cardboard boxes and thin plastic bags offer no barrier. - Clean under your refrigerator and stove regularly. Food debris accumulates there and mice will feed on it. - Keep your kitchen clean, especially at night. Rinse dishes rather than leaving them in the sink overnight. - Take garbage out regularly and use a trash can with a tight-fitting lid.

Water sources: - Fix leaky pipes under sinks and around water heaters. Mice can survive on water condensation from a slow leak. - In the basement, address any standing water or chronic dampness. - Dry up moisture in crawl spaces by improving ventilation.

Nesting material: Mice build nests from soft materials. In a typical home, this means: - Cardboard boxes stored in the garage or basement - Shredded paper in closets or under sinks - Insulation in walls and crawl spaces (mice will shred it for nesting) - Stored fabric, linens, or rags in basements

Clean up cardboard and paper clutter. Store fabric items in sealed plastic bins rather than cardboard boxes. In the garage, use plastic storage bins instead of cardboard for seasonal items.

Page 9: Seasonal Maintenance — Keeping Them Out Year After Year

Mice seek shelter outdoors in the fall and may push inside through spring as they establish new territory. Your maintenance calendar should reflect this.

Spring (April-May): Foundation heaving from winter freeze-thaw cycles creates new gaps. Walk your foundation line in spring and check for new cracks or gaps where utility lines enter. Re-inspect garage door seals after winter — rubber degrades in cold weather.

Summer (July-August): Mouse breeding season peaks. Signs of activity increase as populations grow. This is when you are most likely to notice a new entry point if one opened up. If you live in a rural or semi-rural area, pay extra attention during summer.

Fall (October-November): This is the most important inspection of the year. Before mice seek warm shelter indoors, do a full perimeter walk and seal any gaps that have

opened. Pay special attention to the garage — mice often move into garages in fall before moving into the living space. Install or replace garage door seals before October.

Winter (January-February): Your home should be mouse-free if the fall inspection was thorough. During winter, maintain monitoring. Check traps monthly even if you have had no activity — a single mouse can establish a breeding population quickly.

The annual walk-around: Once per year, do a full exterior walk with a flashlight and a screwdriver. Check every vent cover, every door seal, every point where something penetrates your exterior walls. Any gap you find should be sealed within the same season.

Page 10: Next Steps

You now have the full method. The entry point inspection, the sealing materials, the trap protocol, and the maintenance schedule.

Your bonus checklist covers the full inspection in a printable room-by-room format. It walks you through the same sequence described in this guide — foundation, garage, kitchen, basement, vents — with a checkbox for every gap type.

To get your checklist: Your bonus checklist is included in your Lemon Squeezy library. If you already own any guide from this catalog, check your library for the complete set of companion checklists.

What to do right now: 1. Walk your garage and foundation tonight with a flashlight. 2. Order 12 snap traps, one roll of steel wool, and a tube of caulk. 3. Seal the three gaps you find most easily first — you do not have to do everything at once.

If this guide helped, the checklist is your next step. Work through it room by room and seal what you find.

This guide is for informational purposes only and does not constitute professional pest control advice. For severe infestations or structural concerns, consult a licensed pest control professional.